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ILLINOIS SNAP COSTS

State wins delay on food aid penalty

One-year reprieve doesn't erase threat to budget as eventual share now estimated at \$550 million

By Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois will get an extra year, until October 2028, before it must begin sharing the cost of food assistance benefits with the federal government, after the state's own payment error rate climbed high enough to qualify for a delay built

into a sweeping federal law.

But the reprieve doesn't erase the threat to the state budget. Illinois' eventual share of the cost is now estimated at \$550 million, according to an analysis released this month by the Civic Federation, a fiscal watchdog group, down from an earlier projection of \$700 million, largely because fewer

people are now receiving benefits.

Under the law, states whose Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, or SNAP, error rate exceeds roughly 13% get an extra year before facing cost-sharing requirements that hit most other states starting in October 2027. Illinois' error rate — 14.67% for the federal fiscal year that ended in September 2025 — cleared that threshold, according to experts' analysis of the law and interviews with advocates.

The payment error rate measures over- or underpayments, often caused by mistakes by caseworkers or applicants, not fraud, advocates say.

"It's going to be incredibly important for our elected officials in the General Assembly to start to prepare now for how we're going to absorb that cost, because losing the program is just not an option," said Greater Chicago Food Depository senior policy director Nolan Downey.

So when he saw Illinois' rate of errors on food assistance payments had skyrocketed according to the most recent federal data, Downey had a reaction that might seem unexpected.

"I'm going to be honest that my reaction was relief," Downey said. "I know that's at least one more year that SNAP will not be in jeopardy in the state."

The stakes trace back to the

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ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SWAT officer shot in Albany Park

Members of the Chicago police SWAT team work in an alley in the 4600 block of North Springfield Avenue on Monday. A person was taken into custody Monday afternoon hours after a SWAT team officer was shot during a barricade situation in the Albany Park neighborhood, according to Chicago police. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

US and Iran expand attacks in Gulf region

Houthis in Yemen announce embargo against Saudi Arabia

By Jon Gambrell
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates —The United States military said late Monday it was carrying out its 10th consecutive night of strikes on Iran in a push to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

The renewed bombings came following the death of another American service member, and after Iran launched attacks on American allies Kuwait, Jordan and Bahrain, home of the U.S. Navy's 5th Fleet.

U.S. Central Command said on social media that the latest strikes "are designed to further degrade Iranian military capabilities used to attack commercial shipping" in the strait.

Even as the U.S. and Iran inch closer to all-out war again, glimmers of hope appeared on the diplomatic front, as Iran's interior minister traveled to Pakistan, a key mediator in the conflict, for talks.

The interim deal signed last month that was meant to end the fighting has crumbled. Shipping through the Strait of Hormuz — a vital supply route for world energy

See **IRAN** on Page A10



Chicago Teachers Union members and their allies protest outside Chicago Public Schools headquarters on Monday before a meeting of the Board of Education on the 2027 budget. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Leaders: Pass budget or miss payroll

Board slated to vote on 2026-27 spending plan on July 30

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Despite skepticism from some board members, Chicago Public Schools leaders said Monday that the district's \$9.88 billion budget must be passed this month or it risks missing payroll for its 45,000 employ-

ees. If the budget isn't approved, "the immediate consequence... is we wouldn't be able to make payroll in September," CPS CEO Macqueline King told the Tribune in an interview. "If we're not able to make payroll, then it ultimately disrupts services for our students."

The Board of Education is slated to vote on the district's 2026-27 budget July 30, one month before the state-mandated deadline.

The district laid off more than 700 teachers as it unveiled its spending plan last week. CPS also plans to implement a spending freeze beginning in January and convert five paid professional development days into furloughs if more funding doesn't materialize from the city or state.

While the Chicago Teachers Union called on the board to reject the proposal at Monday's

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Ill. likely to stay in path of wildfire smoke

Air quality affected by more intense blazes, unpredictable winds

By Finnegan Belleau
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As more than 900 wildfires continue to burn across Canada, predicting when air quality conditions will fully return to normal in Illinois and the rest of the Midwest can be tricky.

"Some of these fires in the boreal forest, they don't end until the rain hits," said Craig Clements, director of the Wildfire Interdisciplinary Research Center out of San Jose, California.

Clements said that could be October or November, or as early as next week.

More than 7 million acres in Canada have burned since the start of the year, according to the Canadian Interagency Forest Fire Centre, an organization owned by wildfire management agencies. The group's website says more than 40 started Sunday alone, and many in western Ontario are classified as "out of control."

These fires and at least 19 in Minnesota have sent large concentrations of the pollutant PM2.5 to Illinois. Cook County quadrupled its previous PM2.5 record on Thursday.

An air quality alert ended Monday, but smoke is expected to remain in the area Tuesday, according to AirNow, a website that combines data from county, state and federal air quality agencies nationwide.

The smoke could return later this summer, and air quality issues resulting from wildfires may

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INSIDE

Burnham appointed as new UK leader

Andy Burnham took office as Britain's new prime minister, promising to restore political stability and revive the economy. **Nation & World, Page B4**

Consumer costs slip after months of rises

Inflation saw the biggest single-month drop in six years in June thanks to cheaper clothes, medical care, transportation and falling energy prices. **Business**

Feeling 'really good' after All-Star break

The White Sox's Colson Montgomery gets back to business after a "very good refresher," and it showed against the Blue Jays. **Sports**

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